



THE NEW STAR: The highest wicket taker in the series with 18 wickets, Zaheer Khan made his 2006 stint in county cricket for Worcestershire pay off for India

AP PHOTO/TOM HEVEZI

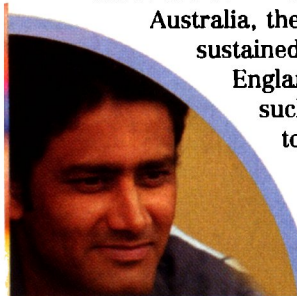
other when you're winning, far more amicable." The Indians are now at the start of what is their toughest season yet: from Independence Day 2007 to the end of February 2008, they will play seven Tests, and a minimum of 26 ODIs and four Twenty20 internationals. It is in the ODI series starting in England on August 21 in Southampton, that the strength of India's bench and all its reserves will be tested. The series will give the exiled Harbhajan Singh and Virender Sehwag an opportunity to make themselves irreplaceable and keep Robin Uthappa in the mix. But the most awaited return will be that of Munaf Patel, last season's most exciting find, following his break due to injury. In the Tests, against opposition as fierce and committed as Pakistan and

Australia, the partnerships that sustained them through

England won't come in such a flood. "Against top teams," said a player, "you will need the big centuries because when sides like Australia get one wicket, they can inevitably turn them into two."

India's

bowlers shared a heavy workload, Khan averaging more than 45 overs per Test and Anil Kumble nearly 50. One of the factors contributing to



"It's still a good WICKET, even I got a 100."

Surprise centurion ANIL KUMBLE offers his opinion on the state of the second day Oval pitch.

NUMBER CRUNCHING

■ England's top six batsmen have scored 1,461 runs between them, averaging 81.16 per man per Test for the series, while the Indian top six have 1,256 runs, averaging 69.77. But India's last five batsman have scored 470 runs between them, averaging 31 per man per Test as opposed to England's 220 averaging 14.7.

■ No frontline Indian batsman has scored a century in this series won by India. The last time this happened was in a rain-affected series against New Zealand in 1996; and the time before that was in 1971, also in England, when India won a famous 1-0 win, their first on English shores.

■ At the age of 36 years and 299 days, Anil Kumble became India's oldest maiden Test centurion in his 118th Test. Interestingly, during the series Kumble was offered a bat contract from English bat manufacturers Gunn & Moore.

■ The partnership of 147 between Wasim Jaffer and Dinesh Karthik was the first opening century stand for India in England since 1979. The two openers together on this tour averaged 53.67.

India's consistent Test success overseas since 2000 is because there have always been at least two quick bowlers firing in a game. Keeping the quicker bowlers fit and fresh and ensuring that those who break down are replaced is vital if India are to keep their momentum going through a long season.

India's composure in the series, barring the odd jelly bean and shoulder-barge, has been impressive. But former England captain Nasser Hussain, a surprisingly empathetic observer, said the "immobility" of the Indian fielding could come back to bite them in Australia where the grounds are larger and the opponents tougher.

Sehwag believes the win in England has set a new benchmark. Gone are the old laments of being poor travellers and of letting opportunities go. This generation has made the breakthrough. He said, "The message to the (other) teams is clear. We can beat anyone, anywhere."

As the sky turned indigo over the Oval, still the team bus waited for its passengers outside the ground. A clutch of fans danced and chanted around it. They had found flags, whistles, a booming *dholak* and a new incantation. "Won-day!" one of them bellowed. Only when the rest chorused 'Motarum' in lusty response did the phrase acquire clear meaning. Wonday Motarum, of course. On the day India took a series off England after 21 years, two days before the 60th anniversary of Indian independence what else would you be shouting on a South London street but 'Wonday Motarum'? Won-day indeed. ■